Challenges and Disparities Faced by LGBTQ+ Students in the Transition to College:
Survey Evidence from the California High School Class of 2023

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Motivation

- The high school to college transition is crucial for young adults (Luh et al., 2023)
- Schools shape students' perceptions of college and future educational attainment (Lynn et al., 2010; Uwah et al., 2008)
- Existing research documents differences in outcomes among historically underserved groups, but limited evidence regarding LGBTQ+ students
- This study provides direct evidence of LGBTQ+ students' experiences before college, focusing on supports, challenges, and disparities

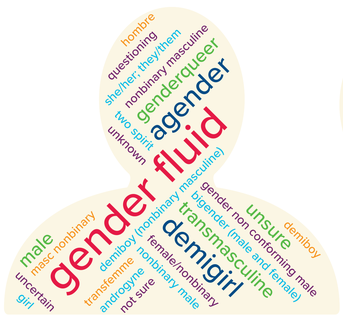
Contribution

- The first large-scale survey to explore high school student experiences and postsecondary plans by diverse sets of gender identities and sexual orientations
- Use validated survey instruments to collect nuanced data on gender identity and sexual orientation
- Add to the growing literature on the academic and social experiences of LGBTQ+ students in high school and college (e.g. Austin et al., 2023; Feldman et al., 2023; Kosciw et al., 2022; Reber & Smith, 2023)
- Contribute to the broader literature on the transition to college by adding new evidence on the experiences of underserved students

Context

- California high school class of 2023 spent a significant portion of early high school learning remotely because of the COVID-19 pandemic
- AB 469 (2021) mandates graduating high school seniors to complete a FAFSA or CADAA (with opt-out waivers)
- Heightened visibility of and backlash against LGBTQ+ people
- Diverse demographics and political leanings in California

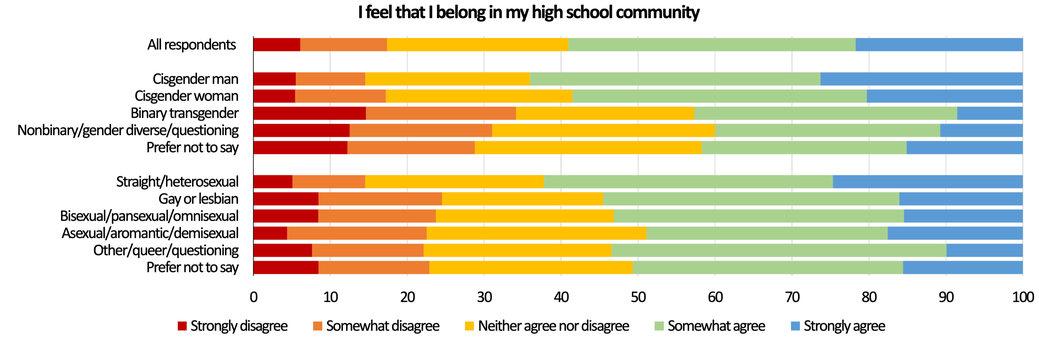
Diverse Gender and Sexuality Descriptors



Key Findings

- Gender and sexual minority students are less likely to report a sense of belonging in their high school community
- Significant gender gap in plans to pursue engineering; more gender and sexuality minority students plan to major in humanities and arts than any other group
- Gender and sexuality minority students report high levels of worry about discrimination based on their gender and sexual orientation

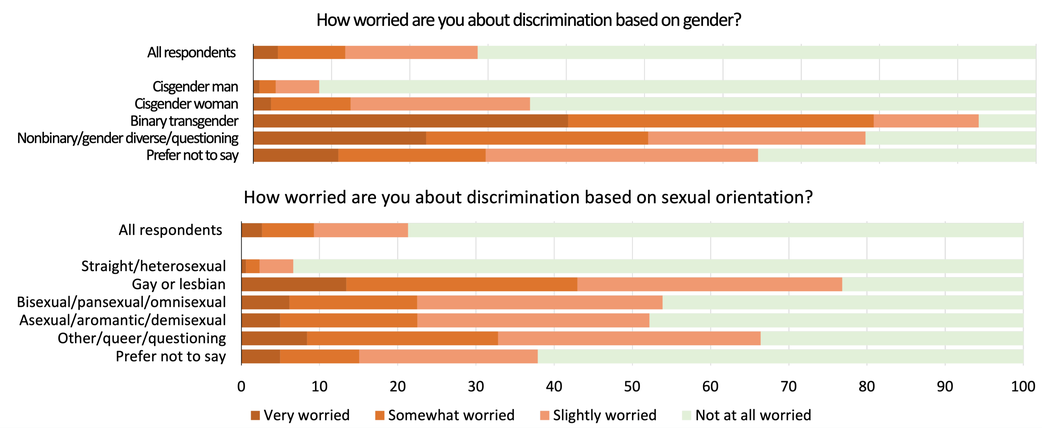
High School Experience



College Plans: Majors

	Business	Engineering	Natural sciences	Social sciences	Humanities and arts	Health sciences	Education	Applied sciences	Public service	Undecided
All respondents	10.3	16.0	15.7	12.3	11.1	15.0	3.7	3.3	4.8	7.9
Cisgender man	12.1	30.0	12.2	7.9	8.9	8.0	1.4	6.9	4.3	8.4
Cisgender woman	9.6	7.8	18.4	14.7	11.2	19.9	4.9	1.2	5.3	7.1
Binary transgender	3.7	17.1	18.3	13.4	28.0	4.9	3.7	4.9	2.4	3.7
Nonbinary/gender diverse/questioning	2.7	11.3	20.0	15.8	26.6	8.1	2.7	3.0	3.6	6.3
Prefer not to say	5.0	19.3	18.6	12.9	17.9	9.3	2.9	2.1	3.6	8.6
Straight/heterosexual	12.0	17.4	15.1	10.5	7.8	16.0	3.5	4.0	5.2	8.4
Gay or lesbian	3.3	10.3	20.9	19.4	20.3	10.9	4.8	2.4	3.9	3.6
Bisexual/pansexual/omnisexual	6.3	12.0	18.6	18.9	18.4	12.1	3.4	1.7	4.2	4.5
Asexual/aromantic/demisexual	6.0	18.7	17.0	11.5	23.6	7.7	2.7	3.8	2.7	6.0
Other/queer/questioning	3.8	11.5	19.2	10.8	25.4	10.0	3.1	4.6	5.4	6.2
Prefer not to say	5.7	16.1	18.9	12.2	16.9	14.3	2.8	1.2	2.9	9.0

Worries about College: Discrimination



Methodology

- Launched an internet-based survey in May 2023 in partnership with the California Student Aid Commission (CSAC)
- Distributed by email to all high school seniors in California who submitted a Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA) or California Dream Act Application (CADAA) for the 2023-24 academic year
- Likert-scale questions capture self-rated subjective students' high school experiences, preparation, plans, and concerns about college
- Open-ended questions capture student voices about the challenges and excitement of going to college
- Gender identities were surveyed using the "two-step" approach recommended by the Williams Institute with the option to specify using free response
- Sexual orientations were surveyed using an instrument adapted from recommendations by the Williams Institute with the option to specify using free response to allow for a broader range of expression

Data

- Our sample includes around 9,230 college-bound HS seniors
- We classify 1,828 as LGBTQ+ students, including
- 417 classified as being non-cisgender
- 1,782 classified as being non-heterosexual

Student Voices

What are you most excited about college?

"Being able to build a community for myself where I truly feel that I belong."

"I'm excited to be myself. I live in a house of five. I'm the youngest of my three siblings, meaning I've had to share a room with my 23-year-old sister since I was born. I've never had privacy and I never felt like I could be myself. To use broad terms, I could never properly express myself as a gay, trans teen. I can't wait to make new friends and enjoy my newfound independence."

"I'm [excited] about moving from home and working to establish my independence."

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